

CASE STUDY

ABRAHAM JOHN THARAKAN, 72
Amalgam Group of Companies, *Kochi*

Annual turnover: ₹700 crore

No. of employees: 1,000 directly and 3,000 on contract

Total exports to the US
₹600 crore *(FY25)*

Likely loss due to the tariffs
₹300 crore

Tharakan, who has been 48 years in the business in Kochi's Willingdon Island, had introduced shrimp and spices for exports over the years, later adding value-added food products with the help of high-tech factories in Kerala and Bengaluru. He had made big inroads into high-value markets and a predominant share of his export orders were from the US.

But, "no doubt", he says, "the new Trump tariff is going to wipe out Indian seafood exporters from the US markets... We won't be able to compete... The trade war is going to affect us in two ways. First, it will reduce our export to the US as no one will be able to export at such high tariffs. Second, we will never have an alternative market and will have to cut down production." ■

if they lack India's skilled workforce required to process shrimps or factories catering to US retailers.

↘ Newer Markets: The search for new markets hasn't been fruitful. China, with an $18.2 billion seafood market, once absorbed 19 per cent of Indian exports. But Beijing is now exporting its own value-added seafood, slashing imports and offering lower prices. Japan, while stable, offers only limited demand. America has been India's best bet for over a decade, with consistent demand and growth of 15-plus per cent. Trump's tariffs have killed that momentum. ■

VICTIMS OF TRUMP TARIFFS

LEATHER

PAINFUL SHOEBITE

One-fifth of Indian leather exports go to the US market. Most units will survive, but the damage is evident across the industry's hubs in Bengal and UP

By ARKAMOY DATTA MAJUMDAR AND AVANEESH MISHRA

↘ The Fallout: India's leather industry, valued at $5.7 billion (Rs 50,160 crore) in exports during 2024–25, faces a sharp setback with the Trump administration's punitive tariffs. The US, which absorbed 21.7 per cent of Indian leather exports in FY25, has overnight become a difficult market to access. The numbers highlight how crucial the US is as a buyer: in 2023-24, America accounted for over 19 per cent (Rs 8,025 crore) of the $4.8 billion (Rs 42,240 crore) worth of leather goods exported.

INDIA'S EXPORTS TO THE US
$1.2 billion
(approx. ₹10,560 cr.)

TOTAL JOBS IMPACTED
200 thousand

The brunt will be borne by eastern India, especially West Bengal. The region exported leather products worth Rs 5,700 crore in 2024-25, with nearly 19 per cent of this directed to the US. In Bengal, 700 leather goods manufacturers, with 550 exporters amongst them, employ 700,000 people. There are around 450 operational tanneries, with 350 more under construction. Bengal specialises in bags, wallets and industrial gloves. Another big hub is the Kanpur–Unnao region in UP, where the loss is estimated to be close to Rs 2,000 crore. The region is home to about 400 tanneries and 600 leather goods units making footwear, saddlery, belts and purses. Over 60 per cent of these units presently sell products to the American market. Together, they employ a million people. Industry leaders warn that nearly 200,000 jobs are already under threat, with the number likely to increase.